

SQUARING OFF

■ Advani takes the BJP by surprise when he dilutes the party's stand on the nuclear deal. He does not inform Rajnath about this.

■ Rajnath glosses over the Uttar Pradesh defeat saying "the cycle of victory and defeat is continuous". Advani snubs him and calls it a "serious setback" and says "not preparing for elections in advance was a costly mistake".

■ Advani suggests setting up six committees to prepare the party's "policy approach". Rajnath sets up two committees and puts two Advani baiters in charge: Yashwant Sinha and Murli Manohar Joshi.

■ Rajnath is conspicuous by his silence during the offensive against Pratibha Patil. Advani and his team handle the campaign.

■ Advani is projected to be the party's prime ministerial candidate. His confidantes claim that according to the British system, the Leader of Party is the PM-in-waiting. A few days later, Rajnath likens himself to a bridegroom leading a bridal party to Delhi.

■ Rajnath is supposed to announce BJP's stand on the reservation policy at the May 2006 National Executive. Advani pre-empts him by giving a statement a day before his speech.

■ Advani announces the twin Suraksha Yatras in Delhi while Rajnath is in Varanasi in March 2006. Some say Rajnath did not even know about the plan till a few minutes before the media was told.

under A.B. Vajpayee's guidance was the official line and one that he endorsed. "There is no change in the party position," he stated. But the larger question remains. How had he fallen into the same trap all over again?

This was hardly the way the regimented BJP has functioned in the 27 years of its existence which, for the most part, was led in turns by Vajpayee and Advani. Since 1986 (except for a brief spell of two years), Advani has either led the party or ruled by proxy through one of his protégés. It was Advani who brought the party, which was a fringe player on the national scene, to the centre stage. It lent him an aura that gave him near absolute control, a power that went beyond the BJP's constitutional stipulations.

Despite quitting as party chief two years ago, Advani continues to guide BJP policy. His statement on the nuclear deal offers an insightful look into the highly individualistic style of his operations. The party stand formulated by the BJP core group and articulated by Yashwant Sinha and Arun Shourie rejected the nuclear deal in its current form. At no point at any party fora did Advani discuss the impact an anti-US stance may have on the party's middle class votebank. On the contrary, this particular discussion first took place at a meeting held at a Hailey Road bungalow in Delhi where a think-tank of security experts and right leaning intellectuals—not all of them formal BJP members—debated the need for a midcourse correction on the party's opposition to the US. It was this lot that finally convinced Advani that he may antagonise the party's traditional votebank, the urban middle class. And Advani was encouraged to take off on another Jinnah-type misadventure. A man, they say, is known by the company he keeps and it's something that Advani should perhaps ponder over.

Why does Advani periodically surface at the oddest of places to put his party in the oddest of situations? The answer lies in the transfer of power to Rajnath, which has hardly been the smoothest of transitions.

When he was forced to quit in December 2005 he had wanted his loyalist, former party chief M. Venkaiah Naidu, to succeed him. But the Sangh thought otherwise and the party's controls went out of Advani's hands.

This soon became a major issue between Advani and the new chief as Rajnath looked to Nagpur rather than Advani's residence at 30 Prithviraj Road for guidance. The feeling of an all pervasive Sangh grew when Rajnath drafted as many as four leaders from the RSS for party work last March and increased the role of *sangathan mantris* (organisation secretaries) within the party. A recent decision by the RSS not to interfere in the day-to-day functioning of the party is being seen as another twist in the Advani-Rajnath powerplay. Ironically, Advani's relations with the RSS were improving when one of his confidantes leaked to the

media a private conversation between him and RSS general secretary Mohan Bhagwat. Not only was Advani's confidence violated but the conversation was misrepresented to claim that the RSS actually supported Advani's line on the nuclear deal. An angry Sangh made its displeasure known. The RSS spokesman reiterated

that the Parivar's opposition to the nuclear deal as stated in a February 2006 resolution remained.

The current turmoil in the UPA has only added to the leadership crisis within BJP. As the country inexorably moves towards an election, it is going to be even more difficult to segregate the role of the BJP chief from that of the leader of Opposition. The question of the party's prime ministerial face that had been put on the backburner also assumes crucial significance. The party is yet to categorically support Advani's claim as the prime ministerial candidate. He had let his desperation slip out during a television interview last year when in response to a question he had replied, somewhat ruefully, that while he had always backed Vajpayee for the prime ministership, "there is no question of anyone returning any favour of this kind".

Both Advani and Rajnath want to revive the party but prefer to follow different roadmaps.